In October 1962, however, Nikita Khrushchev could not converse in English and John Kennedy could not converse in Russian. Any conversation required translators. Nor had the two men talked about ‘something going wrong with the bomb’. At their 1961 summit they held a largely fruitless discussion about a nuclear test ban. Earlier, Khrushchev had ‘gone berserk’ when Kennedy raised the risk of miscalculation as a path to conflict. And when they parted at Vienna, they exchanged threats about the prospect of war.

A summit or conference was a diplomatic option, the more so as the crisis went on. There was little enthusiasm for this in Washington. In his 1990 memoir, Dean Rusk reflected: ‘Chills still run up my spine when I think of what might have happened if Khrushchev and Kennedy had met face-to-face during the Cuban missile crisis.’[15] After his experience at Vienna, however, the President was in no rush to meet his adversary.

David Ormsby-Gore held a similar view. At the outset of the crisis, Macmillan made clear to his ambassador that he ‘could not allow a situation in Europe or in the world to develop which looks like escalating into war without trying some action by calling a conference on my own, or something of the kind, to stop it’.[16] On 24 October the ambassador was tasked by London with establishing Kennedy’s views on a conference. Ormsby-Gore made clear to McGeorge Bundy his own conviction that a summit was not a good idea and that the President ‘should make it very plain’ to Macmillan ‘that this not an acceptable position, and that the U. S. cannot stand down its blockade without progress toward the removal of the missiles.’[17] The British ambassador was counselling the American President to reject the preferences of the British Prime Minister.

Normal diplomatic means of communication usually involved foreign ministries, which proved cumbersome and time-consuming at key moments (though normal diplomatic practices still played a role in the crisis). Some of the diplomatic practices in October 1962 were unusually archaic. Dobrynin recounts that telegrams from the Soviet embassy to Moscow were sent by the Western Union cable company. The embassy had to wait for ‘a black man’ on a bicycle to come and collect them.[18] Sensitive reports also needed encryption in Washington and decryption in Moscow (and vice